

Version #	Date	Details of change	Page / slide no.

Conflict resolution

Learning objective:

11. Understand conflict resolution as the ability to identify and address differences between individuals and/or interest groups.



11a) Know the sources of conflict within a project.

Sources of conflict within a project

- There are many sources of conflict between stakeholders that can occur at various points in the project life cycle.
- Conflict is when two or more parties have a differing opinion or attitude towards something.
- Conflict can arise in a project when these differing opinions and/or opposing attitudes between stakeholders are not easily reconciled.

Concept phase

Securing funding, business case approval or ongoing support for the project.

Balancing stakeholder influences and agreeing high-level scope for the project.

Definition phase

Alignment of scope to project budget and priorities.

Agreeing resource plan and securing resources for the project.

Establishing the various components of the project management plan.

Deployment phase

Maintaining resource availability and commitment.

Deadlines not being met, or progress not as expected.

Agreed plan, processes or methods not being followed.

Transition phase

Acceptance criteria not met.

End-user expectations not achieved.

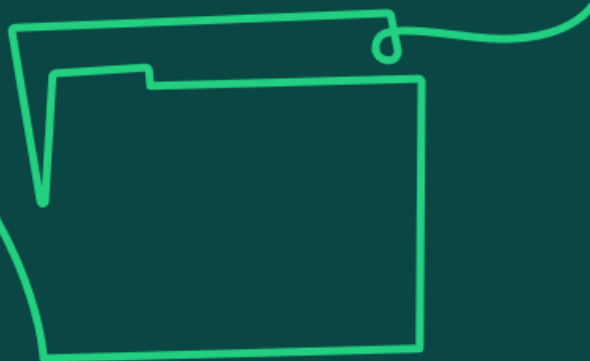
Adoption phase

Outputs not adopted as intended by business as usual.

Benefits realisation phase

Agreement of measurement and realisation.



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11b) Understand that conflict can have both positive and negative impacts within a project.

Conflict: positive and negative

Conflict resolution is the process of identifying and addressing differences that, if left unresolved, could affect objectives.

Conflict should be seen as an opportunity to add value as it:

- Creates open conversations to debate and discuss points.
- Shows feelings and agendas towards the point in question.
- Enables direction to be sought.

Ignoring the conflict and the people involved is not an acceptable or productive way of safeguarding the success of the project.

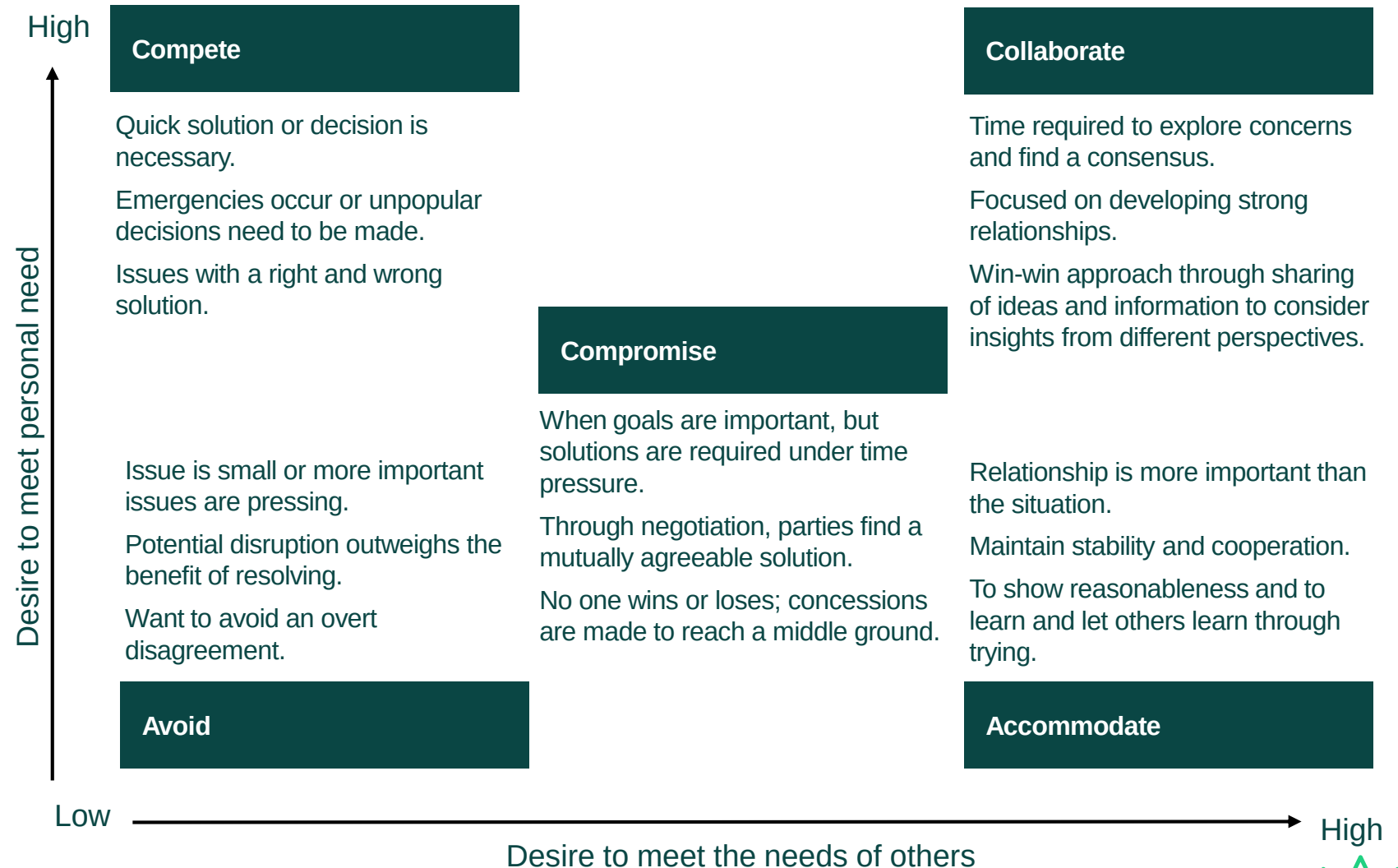


11c) Know ways in which conflict can be addressed in different situations (such as Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument).



Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument

- The Thomas Kilmann model encourages people to think about conflict using two dimensions:
 - The desire to achieve one's own objectives.
 - The desire to help others achieve their objectives.
- Sometimes other parties are required to resolve a conflict to prevent the conflict escalating.
- Clear protocols within a project are needed for when conflicts must be escalated for a resolution or required decision for project delivery and governance.



When to Use Each Mode

Mode	When to use
Competing	When quick, decisive action is vital. Important issues when you know you're right. To protect yourself against people who take advantage of non-competitive behaviour.
Accommodating	When you know that you're wrong. When the issue is much more important to the other person. To build up social credits for later issues.
Avoiding	When an issue is trivial. Temporarily used while gathering information. When the potential damage of confronting a conflict outweighs the benefits of its resolution. When others can resolve the conflict more effectively.
Collaborating	To gain commitment by incorporating other's concerns into a consensual decision, To work through hard feelings which have been interfering with an interpersonal relationship.
Compromising	When goals are moderately important, but not worth the effort or potential disruption of more assertive modes. To achieve temporary settlements to complex issues.



Resolving conflict

Some important considerations for conflict resolution include:

Anticipate different people being involved with different perceptions, agendas and outcomes to be achieved.

Acknowledge very rarely does it just go away.

Resolve and avoid placing blame. Work through solutions that will support achieving the project's aims.

Encourage the sharing of perspectives. Open and honest dialogue will enable better solutions.

Facilitate collaboration to explore potential resolutions.

Neutral – Keep things neutral, using neutral tones, language and body language to avoid defensiveness.